

Voice-First Quotation App for Indian Contractors

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The Problem

India's finishing-trade contractors can price a job in their head in two minutes and cannot put it on paper. That gap costs them work they have already won on skill.

A tiling contractor asked to quote an 850 sq ft flat has three bad options today:

- **Handwritten on a notepad.** Fast, but it reads as informal next to a competitor's printed sheet. Builders and society committees discount him before they read the rate.
- **Ask someone else to type it.** A relative, a shop boy, a cyber cafe. Costs Rs 50-200 and a day or two. By then the client has three other quotes.
- **Give a verbal number.** No record, so scope and payment arguments follow at the end of the job.

Losing one Rs 40,000 job a month to a late or unprofessional quote is roughly Rs 5 lakh of annual revenue. The craft was never the problem; the paperwork was.

The gap is tooling, not intelligence. These contractors are fluent in WhatsApp and voice notes, and not in Excel, Word or English keyboards. Every existing quotation tool assumes all three.

Who Faces This

The user is a solo or small-crew contractor in a finishing trade who quotes directly to clients, not a large EPC firm with an estimation department.

Attribute	Typical profile
Trades	Tiling, flooring, painting, centering/shuttering, AC installation, electrical, plumbing, false ceiling, carpentry
Crew size	5-20 workers
Ticket size per quote	Rs 15,000 – Rs 5,00,000
Quotes sent per month	4-15
Device	Budget Android phone, WhatsApp used daily
Language	Hindi, Marathi, Hinglish; limited English reading
Software used today	None. WhatsApp and the phone dialler

India's construction sector employs roughly 71 million people, of whom about 81% are classified as unskilled. There is no reliable published count of contractors specifically, so the addressable user count in this document is an estimate built from crew sizes and flagged as such.

The Solution

An Android app where the contractor speaks a job in his own language and gets back a professional PDF quotation, sent to the client over WhatsApp in under a minute.

He says: *"Sharma ji ka flat, 850 square foot tiling, 45 rupaye per foot labour, skirting 120 running foot."* He gets a branded PDF with his name, logo, itemised rates, total, advance terms and validity.

The flow: Contractor speaks the job → speech-to-text in Hindi or Marathi → AI extracts line items → edit screen where a tap corrects any number → PDF generated with his branding → sent on WhatsApp.

The app carries the edit screen, which is what makes it trustworthy: line items appear as large cards, a tap

changes a number, a swipe deletes a row, and the total updates live. A WhatsApp-only bot runs the same backend for contractors who will not install anything, reading the summary back for voice confirmation instead.

Why It Stays Accurate

Accuracy comes from narrowing what the AI has to guess, not from a bigger prompt.

- **Trade catalogs as data.** Each trade has its own item list — name, Hindi and Marathi synonyms, default unit, typical rate band. Tiling is per sq ft, centering per sq ft or brass, AC per unit plus copper pipe per running ft, electrical per point. The contractor picks his trade once, so each request carries only 50–100 relevant items.
- **Rate memory per contractor.** His usual rates are stored, so “tiling 850” fills in Rs 45/sq ft automatically. Over time he speaks quantities only.
- **The model extracts; code calculates.** The AI returns structured line items as JSON. Multiplication, GST and rounding happen in code, because language models make arithmetic errors and code does not.
- **Every correction is training data.** Each edit on the review screen logs what the model misheard. New slang and new item names get added to the synonym lists, so accuracy improves without fine-tuning.

The weakest link is speech-to-text on numbers — “saadhe aath sau”, “850” and “eight fifty” all appear — recorded on a noisy site. Sarvam, Bhashini and Whisper should be tested head-to-head on real site voice notes before one is chosen. Expect roughly 90% of line items correct on the first pass, with the rest fixed in seconds on the edit screen.

Market and Pricing

The realistic three-year target is Rs 4–8 Cr ARR from about 20,000–25,000 paying contractors, starting in Maharashtra.

Segment	Basis	Users	Annual value
TAM	All Indian contractors, at Rs 2,000–5,000/year	~5 M (estimated)	Rs 1,000–2,500 Cr
SAM	Urban and semi-urban, finishing trades, smartphone users (~25% of TAM)	~1.2 M	Rs 240–600 Cr
SOM (3 yr)	1.5–2% of SAM, Maharashtra first, then Hindi-belt states	20,000–25,000	Rs 4–8 Cr

The contractor count is derived from ~71 million construction workers at an assumed 10–15 workers per contractor. It needs validation on the ground before it goes into any investor material.

Pricing. A flat Rs 5,000/year is too steep as an entry price — these buyers pay small amounts to strangers, not Rs 5,000 upfront — but it works as a top tier.

Tier	Price	Includes
Free	Rs 0	5 quotes a month, app branding on the PDF
Basic	Rs 199/month or Rs 1,999/year	Unlimited quotes, own logo, saved rates
Pro	Rs 4,999/year	Invoices, advance and payment tracking, multiple sites, helper login

Comparable global tools run Rs 700–2,500/month (Joist: free tier, then \$8–\$32/month), while free Indian quotation apps already exist — none of them voice-first or usable by this audience. Cost to serve is Rs 1–2 per quote, so margins hold at every tier.

Go-to-Market

These users will not discover or self-learn an app, so distribution is physical: one city, two trades, dealers doing the introductions.

1. **Concierge test (month 0-1).** Find 20-30 tiling and painting contractors through tile shops, hardware stores and live society interior jobs in Pune. Make their quotes manually from their voice notes. The signal to watch is whether they come back next week unprompted.
2. **Dealer-led launch (month 1-4).** Tile, paint and hardware dealers meet these contractors daily. A counter QR code and the dealer's name printed on the quote as recommended supplier gets the dealer repeat buyers and gets us free distribution. Target 10-15 dealers producing 300-500 contractors.
3. **Assisted onboarding.** One field person (Rs 15-20k/month) installs the app, sets the trade and rates, and gets the first quote sent on the spot. Without this step most signups never produce a quote.
4. **Virality built into the artifact.** Every PDF footer reads *Banaya [App] se — free app*. Quotes travel to clients, builders and rival contractors, so each one advertises. One free month per referral.
5. **Content.** Short Hindi and Marathi reels — “bol ke quotation banao, 30 second mein” — pushed into contractor WhatsApp groups. Paint companies' painter loyalty programs are the larger partnership channel later.

Build cost. Four to six weeks of in-house development on Flutter or React Native. Play Store registration is Rs 2,100 one-time, hosting Rs 1-3k/month, speech and LLM inference Rs 1-2 per quote. Six-month budget is Rs 3-5 lakh, of which under Rs 50,000 is technology — the rest is the field person, dealer incentives and content.

Metrics that decide continuation: first quote sent within 24 hours of install, quotes per user per week, 30-day retention, free-to-paid conversion, and acquisition cost held under Rs 400 per paying user.

Where This Goes Next

As pure quotation SaaS this is a Rs 5-10 Cr business. The quote is better understood as the entry point that creates a data asset nobody else holds.

Once a contractor quotes through the app, the natural next layers are invoices against those quotes, advance and balance tracking, and payment reminders to clients. That produces a verified record of jobs won, amounts billed and payments received for an operator who has never had a credit history.

Three revenue lines open from there:

- **Material dealers** paying to reach contractors at the moment a job is priced, when material choices are still open.
- **Payment collection** on the invoices already flowing through the product.
- **Working-capital credit** underwritten on the contractor's own job and payment data — the largest of the three, and the reason this is worth building beyond a subscription business.

Immediate next step: build the tiling and painting item catalogs and the extraction schema, then run the concierge test with 20-30 contractors before writing app code.

Sources

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